

Everything Changes at 10% Body Fat

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Aug 04, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7DpZNsPXz0> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Reaching 10% body fat unlocks better looks, peak testosterone, optimal insulin sensitivity, and faster muscle growth. Brandon Carter explains the hormonal science and delivers a concrete diet, protein, tracking, and walking plan to get there fast.

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Why 10% Body Fat Is a Cheat Code 0:00

- Getting to 10% body fat changes your entire experience — you look better, feel better, and people treat you differently
- Hollywood examples used to illustrate how leanness, not size, creates an impressive physique:
 - Brad Pitt in *Fight Club* (90s) — 5'5", 155 lbs
 - Zac Efron in *Baywatch* — 5'10", 168 lbs
 - Ryan Reynolds — 6'2", 180 lbs
 - Christian Bale — 6'0", 175 lbs
 - Michael B. Jordan in *Creed* — 6'0", 175 lbs
 - All look remarkable because they are **lean**, not because they are massive
- You will look bigger at 10% body fat even if you've lost weight
 - Example: people tell Brandon he looks bigger after a cut — he didn't gain weight, he lost it
 - Muscle covered by fat looks like bulk, not definition
 - "Putting on five pounds of muscle at 20% body fat is like a fat girl with big titties. Yeah, you'll still do it, but you're not going to brag about it."

- At 10% body fat with 5 lbs of muscle added: "you will look majestic"

The Hormonal Science: Fat, Testosterone, and Insulin 1:20

- Fat tissue is not passive dead weight — it is a highly endocrine-active organ
- Contains an enzyme called **aromatase**
 - Aromatase actively converts free testosterone into estrogen
 - Higher estrogen + lower testosterone = harder to build muscle AND easier to store fat
- If you're already over 15% body fat, your testosterone is suboptimal for muscle building
- Stripping down to 10% body fat minimizes aromatase activity and keeps testosterone at its peak
 - Going too low (4–5% body fat) will actually drop testosterone — 10% is the sweet spot
- Carrying excess fat also reduces **insulin sensitivity**
 - Less insulin sensitivity means nutrient partitioning is impaired
 - When bulking in a caloric surplus at high body fat, more excess calories convert to fat rather than muscle
- Being lean improves insulin sensitivity, which optimizes nutrient partitioning
 - Excess calories and nutrients are biased toward muscle cells instead of fat cells

Getting to 10% body fat sets up a hormonal environment optimized for building muscle — bulking while fat means your hormones are out of whack and you'll gain more fat than muscle anyway.

Fat Loss First: The Quick Win Strategy 3:58

- For skinny-fat people or those who need to lose fat AND build muscle: **lose the fat first**
- Biological reason fat loss is faster than muscle building:
 - Building muscle requires: lifting, breaking down muscle fibers, waiting for them to regrow stronger
 - Losing fat requires: fat cells simply shrink
- Go on an intense diet, get as lean as you want to be, then build muscle — faster progress overall
- Immediate payoff: you look better right away and become "presentable"
- Once lean, you may realize you need less muscle than you thought
- If you do want more muscle, your hormonal environment is now primed to build it efficiently
- Exception — simultaneous fat loss and muscle gain:
 - This is possible **only in your first year** of serious, structured weightlifting
 - Example: Brandon's client Greg ("Young Candlestick") — was bulky with excess fat, followed a structured plan for the first time, lost fat and gained a little muscle simultaneously

The Game Plan: Calories and Protein 5:55

- **Calorie formula:** body weight in pounds × 10 = daily calorie target

- Example: 200 lb person → 2,000 calories per day
- "It's not a lot."
- **Protein formula:** 1 gram of protein per pound of current body weight (NOT goal body weight)
 - Example: 200 lb person → 200 g protein per day
 - Brandon explicitly rejects the "goal body weight" version of this formula
 - Even a 300 lb person should get 300 g of protein — Brandon reports getting 300 g himself regularly with no issues
- Two key reasons for high protein during a cut:
 - Retains more muscle mass while in a deficit
 - If it's your first year lifting seriously, high protein enables simultaneous muscle gain
 - "If you want to maintain your muscle on a cut, get more protein than you need. Go overboard."

Thermic Effect of Food: Why Protein Wins 6:39

- Different macronutrients burn different amounts of calories during digestion (thermic effect of food)

Macronutrient	Thermic Effect (% of calories burned in digestion)	Net calories absorbed from 100 cal
Fat	0–3%	~97 calories
Carbohydrates	5–15%	85–95 calories
Protein	20–30%	70–80 calories

- Protein burns the most calories just from being digested — a "real cheat code"
- Keeping protein high serves double duty: muscle retention AND increased caloric burn

Tracking Calories with AI (Claude) 8:31

- Brandon used **MyFitnessPal** for decades but has switched to **Claude** (AI)
 - Also works with ChatGPT, likely works with Gemini and Grok (untested)
- His workflow:
 - Starts a new chat every month with a detailed custom prompt (prompt available via link in description)
 - Logs meals by typing or describing what he ate; Claude calculates macros and gives a running daily total
 - Weighs sauces and condiments for precision ("I'm a psycho")
 - When a scale isn't available, takes a photo of the food and asks Claude to estimate ounces and macros
 - Uploads photos of nutrition labels directly into the chat
 - Syncs with **Apple Health**, which connects to his **Oura Ring** for calorie burn data
 - Receives an end-of-day summary: total calories, all macros, water intake, calories burned, and deficit/surplus

- Example: on a maintenance day, he was in a **300 calorie deficit**; on a cut that number would be **~1,000 calories**
- "This is the best way I found to actually track calories. And I've tried everything over the last 27 years in the fitness industry."
- Weekly weigh-ins: weigh yourself every week and adjust calories based on results

20,000 Steps a Day Protocol 10:05

- Walking 20,000 steps per day is described as "the cheat code" for getting super lean
- Sample daily schedule to hit 20,000 steps:
 - 30-minute walk in the morning → ~3,000 steps
 - 30-minute walk after lunch → ~3,000 steps
 - 10-minute walk every hour at work (set an alarm) → ~8,000 steps total
 - 1-hour walk after work in the evening → ~6,000 steps
 - Total: ~20,000 steps
- "You do that, the fat is going to melt off."

GLP-1 Appetite Suppressants (Tirzepatide) 10:52

- Brandon recommends consulting a doctor before using any GLP-1 medication
- Drug mentioned: **Tirzepatide** (brand name: Zepbound/Mounjaro)
 - Shuts off hunger almost entirely — eating only 2,000 calories becomes effortless
 - Brandon himself takes it even during maintenance phases because his natural appetite drives him toward 4,000–5,000 calories per day
 - Called it "the closest thing to a miracle drug"
 - Did a severe cut experiment on Tirzepatide for one month — worked so well he recommended it to his mother and best friend Jeremy
- **Retatrutide** ("Rea") mentioned as an alternative some people prefer
 - Jeremy tried it but it affected his heart rate due to a different receptor pathway — Brandon advises against it
 - Brandon also won't buy it from Chinese websites
- Brandon gets his Tirzepatide prescribed by his doctor; notes insurance may not cover it but he pays out of pocket
- Current experiment: eating at ~maintenance (~3,000 calories at 6'2", ~197 lbs) with **300 g protein/day** while on Tirzepatide

The RIP Roadmap Tool 12:49

- Free AI tool Brandon built called the **RIP Roadmap** (link in description)
- How it works:

- Input your height and weight
- Upload a photo of yourself
- Tell the AI your goals
- AI analyzes everything and outputs:
 - Your estimated current body fat percentage
 - Exactly how many pounds of fat you need to lose to reach 10% body fat
 - Your exact calorie and protein targets (based on the formulas above)
 - A week-by-week progress projection
- Includes a **carb/fat slider**: adjust the ratio to your preference (high carb or low carb/high fat)
 - Brandon personally runs low carb; notes both approaches are valid
- Also mentioned: **10 online training client spots** open this month (application link in description)